



Doyen of the sport: P. R. Sreejesh, who has played over 300 international matches, has been one of India's most consistent players. He has helped India win several tournaments, including the Olympic bronze medals at the Tokyo and Paris Olympics.

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For years, fans have rallied behind Sreejesh, chanting his name and marvelling at his heroic saves. Now, they'll struggle to adjust to his absence, missing the familiar sight of the tall, masked goalkeeper standing guard in India's net.

Life, however, moves on.

His teammates will eventually adapt to the silence, no longer hearing the sharp, commanding

words that Sreejesh, with his experience, used to rally them into the right positions and tighten the defence — words he humorously referred to as "songs" rather than the abuses they sometimes were.

They all understood that it was all for the team, with nothing personal against anyone.

Hailing from Kerala, a non-traditional hockey state, 36-year-old Sreejesh has seen it all — from India's failure to qualify for the Olympics in 2008, to not winning a single match in 2012, to reaching the quarterfinals in 2016, and finally securing bronze medals in both 2020 and 2024. He poured his heart and soul into the sport.

As he walked up to the post for the last time in the bronze medal

match against Spain at the historic Yves du Manoir Stadium in Paris, his mind flashed back through his journey.

"I just wanted to have my own moment, to recall all the memories from the day I first stepped onto the hockey field, the first time I put on the pads, and the day I got into the Indian camp for the first time back in 2002. My first international match. I just went through it all, revisiting those moments," said an emotional Sreejesh.

For his astonishing saves against Great Britain, playing a key role in a 10-man India's victory in the quarterfinals, former India captain and Hockey India (HI) president Dilip Tirkey hailed Sreejesh as the "God of Indian hockey."